you, who had come to Mexico to be an artist. Your mother Sarita, you say, was not an artist and had never been to Mexico. But then, had she? Where do Amrita and (Ro)Sarita meet and part? Perhaps in portraits of artists as young women, now yoked together in the land of that quintessential artist of the violently fantastical imagination, Frida.

Desai's tale is like a brief, sharp flash of light before the lighthouse beam turns. As she remarked about *rosarita* in an interview to *The Guardian*, "I'm not writing a Victorian novel starting with childhood and going on to old age and death! This is just one little section. A little piece of their lives. A fragment." This is what remains of the bildungsroman, a novel form that traces a life from birth to death, when it is leached to a novel-fragment: it eschews a beginning, middle and end, and plucks out a segment like a single slice of orange, redolent of the fragrance of the rest you do not taste. *rosarita* is written in the second person—'you'—where the reader is transformed into a protagonist. You are cast in(to) this story and led astray often, by what could simply be the wildness of your imagination in a tango with a Frida Kahlo-esque Mexico.

If you expect Desai's *rosarita* to resolve the mystery of (Ro)Sarita in Mexico, you are in pursuit of a red herring. And yet you, Bonita, find yourself catapulted into this pursuit, of seeking the truth about your mother's secret sojourn to San Miguel in some distant past; you suddenly recall her vicious headaches late in the night as she sat hunched over a book or amidst boxes of paraphernalia that could have been her hidden art supplies, your father dismissive and sullen of her secrets.

You are privy here to a very distilled, very different Anita Desai, holding up a jagged, translucent jewel to lamplight, with shadows falling everywhere

There is much about your parents that you do not know. There is much about difficult histories—yours, and theirs—that you allow erasures of. You fly the nest, in search of new worlds and new adventures, only to discover uncanny transnational reverberations across generations, made up of buried ancestral histories of blood and death—trains carrying heaps of bodies across newly-drawn boundaries during the Partition of the Indian subcontinent, similar to the blood spilled during the Mexican revolution, a few decades earlier. Your mother bore grievous family memories of those trains like wounded works of art, that you had—unknown to you—to travel to Mexico to decipher.

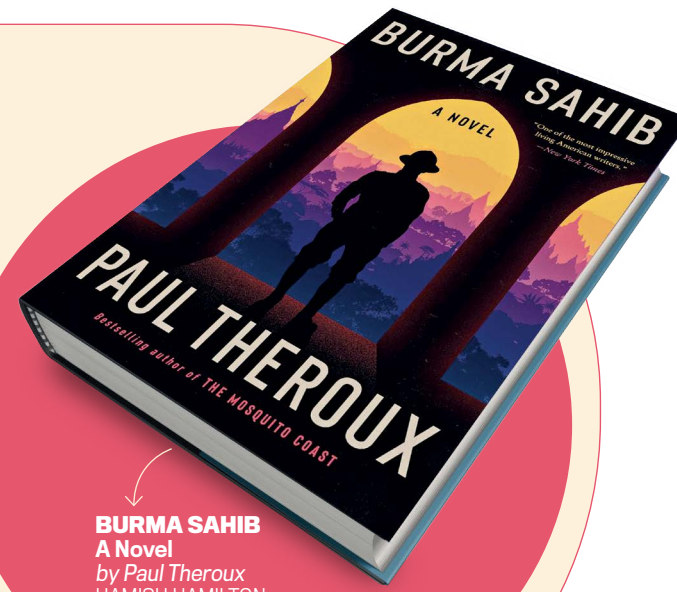
You are privy here to a very distilled, very different Anita Desai, holding up a jagged, translucent jewel to lamplight, with shadows falling everywhere. There is whimsy and obscurity; history, art, travel, exotic sound and scape; the impenetrable passion of family, strangers, loves and sorrows. And amidst it all, there is you, dropped *in medias res*, to code, decode and re-code, what may have been, or not been at all. ■

–Brinda Bose

junior agent paid by the Raj to sell opium to China, Orwell was further embarrassed by having a Franco-Burmese "Chi-Chi" grandmother who smoked cheroots, "the dead wood of the Empire".

Standing almost twice the height of the Burmese, Orwell as a uniformed lamppost was an easy target for their insults but in addition to the demoralising nature of his police work was the social tension between the laidback Burmese and the industrious Indian settlers. To the seditious villagers and patriotic monks of the Buddhist pagodas, both the British and their Indian enforcers were "as welcome as a turd in the punch bowl". Having put Orwell through the wringer, Theroux poetically arranges for his revenge against the humiliations meted out by Orwell's hen-pecked Scots superior whose wife had hoped to snare "Lofty" into marrying their daughter. (Instead Orwell has a roaring affair with the daughter's English chaperone!) Driven by taunts of not being brutal enough to be an Imperial Policeman, Orwell shoots the symbolic golden goose on which the profits of the Empire's teak trade depend. With the surrender of the offending rifle to his enraged superior, Orwell declares his freedom from the empire's moral squalor: "Stick it up your arse, Jock." ■

–Bill Aitken



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